



කාන්තාවන් පිළිබඳ ජාතික කොමිෂන් සභාව
பெண்கள் பற்றிய தேசிய ஆணைக்குழு
National Commission on Women



National Commission on Women Strategic Plan 2027 – 2031

August 2026

Contents

Acknowledgements.....	03
Executive Summary.....	04
1. Introduction.....	06
2. Strategic Planning Process.....	07
3. Contextual Analysis.....	08
4. NCW's Strategic Plan (2027 – 2031).....	12
5. Monitoring, Evaluation & Learning Framework.....	19
6. Annex 1: MEL Framework.....	20

Acknowledgements

The National Commission on Women extends its sincere appreciation and gratitude to all those who contributed to the preparation of its first Strategic Plan.

The Commission gratefully acknowledges the professional guidance, technical expertise, and dedicated support provided by *Strategic Inspirations Pvt. Ltd.* throughout the strategic planning process. Special appreciation is extended to Mr. Peter Rezel, Senior Consultant and Managing Director, for his leadership, commitment and invaluable guidance in facilitating the development of this Strategic Plan. The Commission also acknowledges with appreciation the invaluable contributions of Ms. Niyanthini Kadirgamar, Ms. Rushika Kannangara, Ms. Nilakshi De Silva, Mr. Mirak Raheem and Ms. Krishna Velupillai for their professional support and assistance in shaping the strategic framework of the Commission.

The Commission expresses its heartfelt gratitude to Dr. Mario Gomez, Executive Director of the International Centre for Ethnic Studies (ICES), for generously providing the premises and facilities for the strategic planning discussions, thereby creating a conducive environment for consultation and deliberation.

The Commission sincerely thanks the Bandaranaike Centre for International Studies (BCIS) and its Executive Director Ms. Priyanthi Fernando for their generous support in providing office space, ensuring continuous assistance to the Commission during its early operationalization.

The Commission acknowledges and sincerely appreciates the valuable contributions of all stakeholders, including civil society organisations, particularly women's rights organisations and activists, who participated in online and in-person consultations and contributed meaningfully to the development of this Strategic Plan.

The Commission places on record its appreciation to the Chairperson, Commissioners and Executive Director for their keen participation, commitment, and extensive deliberations throughout the strategic planning process.

The National Commission on Women remains firmly committed to fulfilling its mandate as an independent statutory Commission and to advancing the rights of women, promoting gender equality, and strengthening women's empowerment through the effective implementation of its strategic priorities.

National Commission on Women
August 2026

Executive Summary

The National Commission on Women (NCW) was established under the Women Empowerment Act No. 37 of 2024. In September 2025, the first Commission comprising seven members was appointed by the President, upon the recommendation of five members by the Constitutional Council, and two members by the Women Parliamentarians' Caucus.

As a new state institution with a broad mandate and high public expectations, the NCW initiated a strategic planning process to clarify its vision and mission and systematically identify its priorities for the next five years (2027–2031).

The strategic plan was developed with two broad objectives:

- 1) To develop the Vision and Mission of the new Commission to be aligned with the mandate provided in the Women Empowerment Act, National Policy on Gender Equality and Women's Empowerment, Government's other national policy frameworks and the concluding observations from the UN Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW) into an actionable and results-oriented strategic plan for the five-year period.
- 2) To develop a detailed annual plan and budget to secure the necessary funding to fully operationalize the institution for the year 2027.

The process included a review of the Women Empowerment Act, all relevant key policy documents, NCW's organisational documents, other relevant research and consultation reports, and documents of other independent national commissions in Sri Lanka and comparative regional experience. The consultation process included focus group discussions and key informant interviews with numerous individuals and women's rights organisations across the country.

The strategic plan was shaped by an analysis of the key areas arising from the relevant policy documents, opportunities and challenges arising from the global and national context for women's rights and gender equality, vis-à-vis the organisational strengths and potential weaknesses of NCW.

The NCW's Strategic Plan was developed through a highly participatory process involving the full and active engagement of the Chairperson, Members of the Commission, and the Executive Director. The Commission developed the programmatic framework, results and monitoring framework and institutional strategies.

The Vision and Mission of the NCW as articulated in the Strategic Plan are as follows:

- **Vision:** *All women in Sri Lanka enjoy their right to equality, dignity and justice.*
- **Mission:** *To protect and promote women's rights and gender equality through independent oversight, advocacy, and strengthening inclusive participation and accountability.*

The Strategic Plan 2027-2031 has been clustered around three thematic areas:

1. **Access to Justice:** To promote gender responsive laws and policies relating to access to justice, equal participation and representation.
2. **Safety, Peace and Security:** To ensure gender-responsive access to justice is ensured in relation to safety, peace and security. This theme includes two sub-themes: a) Sexual and Gender-Based Violence and b) Women, Peace and Security.
3. **Access to Resources and Opportunities:** To promote gender responsive laws, policies and practices in the workplace, access to gender responsive health services that cover all phases of a woman's life, and gender-responsive actions to climate change and disasters. This theme includes three sub-themes: a) Economic Justice; b) Access to Women's Health and c) Environment, Climate Change and Disasters.

Across the three thematic areas, the NCW will implement strategic interventions through its core mandate functions: investigation and inquiry, litigation and mediation, referrals and collaboration, monitoring, research and fact-finding, policy and law reform and advocacy.

The National Fund for Women will be administered and managed by NCW and will contribute towards both the delivery of its thematic areas and institutional strategies.

The thematic programme will be supported and anchored by the strategies for institutional development. As a newly established Commission, greater focus has been placed on key aspects of Institutional Development such as governance, infrastructure, finance management, human resources, communications, outreach and public engagement. Establishing NCW's status as an independent commission and a leading body in promoting and protecting women's rights forms an important part of institutional development.

A results-oriented approach was adopted for the strategic plan, with indicators identified at outcome and output levels for each of the sub-themes. A Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning (MEL) Framework was developed for NCW to assess its results. The MEL framework outlines how periodic data collection and analyses will guide and accompany implementation; and how the information generated from the MEL framework will be reflected upon and used to improve NCW's performance.

An analysis of NCW's social actors and collaborators for each of the thematic areas was developed. Given that it is a new Commission, establishing relationships and collaborations will be a major focus in the next five years.

1. Introduction

The National Commission on Women (NCW) is an independent, statutory body established in September 2025 under the Women Empowerment Act No. 37 of 2024. It is responsible for promoting, protecting, and advancing women's rights in Sri Lanka, while also overseeing the implementation of national policies related to gender equality.

The Commission is mandated by law to promote, protect, and advance women's rights in Sri Lanka, by introducing mechanisms to give effect to Sri Lanka's obligations under the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW)¹. It is also mandated to protect women from discrimination based on gender and sexual orientation², and raise awareness and disseminate information regarding women's rights and internationally recognized standards relating to women's rights³.

The mandate of the NCW has been clearly outlined in Section 2 of the Act and must be read together with Section 6 of the Act which sets out the powers, functions and duties of the Commission as follows:

- To investigate complaints, intervene in proceedings, request for information and conduct public inquiries on incidents infringing on women's rights, and to litigate or mediate on the same;
- To liaise with state institutions and authorities to ensure compliance and provide recommendations for laws, policies and practices to be in line with accepted norms and standards of women's rights, including the CEDAW Committee's Concluding Observations;
- To formulate a national policy and a framework for the advancement and empowerment of women;
- To undertake research and raise awareness for the promotion and protection of women's rights and gender equality;
- To establish the National Fund for Women, receive funds from the parliament and other donors, manage and disburse the fund;
- To establish and maintain regional offices.

As per Section 5 of the Act, the Commission comprises seven members. All Commissioners are appointed by the President based on recommendations for five members by the Constitutional Council, and for two members by the Women Parliamentarians' Caucus. The Act provides that at least five members, including the Chairperson, be women. The members are required to be persons having distinguished themselves in public life with proven knowledge, experience and eminence in the fields of law or legislation, trade unionism, management and administration, economic

¹ Section 2(b), Women Empowerment Act No. 37 of 2024

² Section 2(d), Women Empowerment Act No. 37 of 2024

³ Section 6(m), Women Empowerment Act No. 37 of 2024

development, health, education, empowerment of women or have committed to increase the employment potential of women.⁴

Working with specific vulnerable communities including women affected by conflict, military and police widows, women ex-combatants, female-headed households, women with disabilities, older women, transgender communities, women in the plantation sector, migrant women workers, and women in the informal economy and other marginalized communities are identified as part of its mandate.

As an independent commission, NCW can obtain state funds, external funds, donations and gifts as well as set up its own organisational structure and staff and manage its assets to fulfil its mandate.

The NCW, as a significant addition to existing independent commissions, is the result of a much-felt national need and a long-standing demand by the women's rights movement in Sri Lanka, as well as the State's fulfilment of its international obligations under CEDAW. It responds to the need for an independent commission entrusted with the distinctive statutory power to promote, protect and fulfil women's rights and gender equality.

2. The Strategic Planning Process

A result-oriented strategic planning approach was adopted identifying key result areas, outcomes, outputs and strategic actions for five years from 2027 – 2031.

The process included an in-depth analysis and review of all relevant key documents, including the Women Empowerment Act, the National Policy Framework (2025), the National Policy on Gender Equality and Women's Empowerment (2023-2033), the Multisectoral National Action Plan to Address Sexual and Gender Based Violence (2024-2028), the National Action Plan on Women, Peace and Security (2023-2027), and the 2025 Concluding Observations of the CEDAW Committee. NCW's internal organisational documents including the annual set up plan, organogram, staffing requirements, guidelines and protocols as well as NCW's public interventions so far were included in the review. Furthermore, other relevant research and consultation reports on specific themes relevant to NCW's mandate were reviewed. Documents of other independent national commissions in Sri Lanka and of the Bangladesh Women's Affairs Reforms Commission were reviewed. The strategic plan was informed by the priorities outlined in the key documents reviewed in addition to the insights gathered through wide-ranging consultations.

The consultation process included focus group discussions and key informant interviews with representatives of women's rights organisations, civil society organisations, and other key stakeholders including state institutions and professional bodies. The consultations gathered insights into the context, deeper understanding of issues and experiences of women's collectives and organisations from different sectors and on their expectations of the NCW.

⁴ Section 5(3), Women Empowerment Act No. 37 of 2024

NCW's first Strategic Plan was developed with the full and active participation of all seven Commissioners and the Executive Director, drawing on consultations with present and former commissioners of other independent commissions in Sri Lanka, as well as the Bangladesh Women's Affairs Reforms Commission, to better understand institutional challenges and strategies. While efforts were made to facilitate engagement with the relevant ministries and the Women Parliamentarians Caucus, the limited timeframe available for the process presented challenges in scheduling these meetings.

3. Contextual Analysis

a. Global trends in the discourse on Women's Rights and Gender Equality

The global context for women's rights and gender equality is undergoing a historic shift. Western countries are moving from a broadly pro-women's rights agenda toward increasingly regressive positions. This is evident in changes to legal protections, including reproductive rights and voting rights, declining state funding for gender-related research and programmes in the global north, and unprecedented cuts to gender-focused development assistance to the global south, with consequences for countries such as Sri Lanka.

The understanding of gender and sexuality as socially constructed and non-fixed categories is increasingly being challenged by narratives emphasizing fixed biological identities. Social media trends promoting traditional gender roles, blaming women for the 'lonely male' phenomenon, and the rejection of scientific research and higher education are contributing to this shift. These trends are also undermining research and knowledge on women's health and wellbeing.

The resurgence of racial and economic supremacy, resource extraction and protectionism in Western democracies is disrupting global economic systems. Erratic trade policies and tariffs are affecting global value chains and creating economic insecurity for women dependent on export industries and migrant labour. At the same time, climate change denial is intensifying climate emergencies in vulnerable countries such as Sri Lanka. Rapid and largely unregulated development of AI is contributing to resource scarcity and displacing human labour, disproportionately affecting women. Climate change, unemployment, indebtedness and conflict are creating new vulnerabilities, with Muslim, migrant and transwomen particularly targeted by right-wing and authoritarian forces.

Women have historically relied on international norms, the UN system and human rights frameworks to advance rights domestically. However, the weakening of Western liberal democracies has also undermined these multilateral mechanisms. The current resurgence of right-wing populism and anti-women agendas is being reinforced by alliances between religious nationalist forces, corporate interests and extremely wealthy individuals. These forces are contributing to new forms of patriarchal control and threatening democratic processes, including through electoral interference, anti-women narratives and spread of disinformation through social media.

At the same time, growing discontent over inequality, genocide and climate injustice is mobilizing a new generation for justice and systemic change. Gen-Z-led movements have emerged across continents, including South Asia, with young women increasingly participating and taking leadership. Progressive movements are advancing women's rights in some contexts, while influential religious and civil society voices are demanding accountability and protection of rights. Women-led grassroots initiatives are exploring alternative economic models, local knowledge and responses to climate and food insecurity, while decolonization has emerged as a counter-discourse to the continued exploitation of nature and labour in the Global South.

Women's movements are increasingly converging around autonomous feminist approaches that are anti-imperialist, anti-capitalist and anti-racist. There is renewed urgency to protect international frameworks developed through decades of women's activism on gender and sexual identities, women's labour, violence against women and the environment. As the first independent women's commission in Sri Lanka, NCW recognizes the need to assess these emerging global opportunities and challenges and their implications for shaping its own interventions over the next five years.

b. Strengthening Women's Rights and Gender Equality in Sri Lanka

Sri Lanka has had its own trajectory of addressing women's rights and gender equality. It stands out as one of the oldest democracies in Asia and for achieving universal franchise at an early stage compared to other countries. Sri Lanka's higher Human Development Indicators, in women's literacy and health, through the provision of free health and free education, have often been lauded in the international arena.

While the achievement of women's democratic rights is commendable and to be safeguarded, women's democratic participation has not yet translated into women's representation and equal participation at decision-making levels. Women continue to face scrutiny and gendered attacks for engaging in the public sphere as politicians or activists. Women's experiences of violence emerging in domestic spaces, workplaces and public settings and during emergencies including war and climate disasters remain high. Their access to justice and due process are often hindered. Law enforcement is weak; women face obstacles in filing cases under the Prevention of Domestic Violence Act and obtaining maintenance payments. Delayed justice often increases safety issues and complexities for women. Discriminatory personal laws have also stifled women's access to justice.

Free public education has ensured higher literacy levels for women. However, gender stereotypes often curtail women from offering certain subjects and entering certain academic and professional disciplines. The lack of access to basic infrastructure, including clean bathrooms, support for menstrual hygiene, safe transport and nutritious food have stifled girls' education. Women face discrimination when participating in sports, and entering and advancing in the workplace, due to resource constraints and discrimination based on their attire, as well as cultural and religious beliefs. While access to education for girls and women is a remarkable achievement, the content and curriculum in schools and universities often reinforce negative gender stereotypes, which impact negatively on women.

Sri Lanka's extensive healthcare system has provided free health services to women, including community health, primary health and preventive health services. Midwives have the highest reach, including in rural and remote areas, among all public sector service providers. Yet, women face challenges in specific areas, such as access to informed and free sexual and reproductive health services. Harmful and non-consensual cultural practices continue in both public and private health sectors. The criminalization of abortion, even in cases of rape and incest, continues to violate women's right to bodily autonomy.

Women often face discrimination in the workplace during and after pregnancy. Furthermore, companies are attempting to shift the burden of maternity benefits to employee trust funds. The lack of adequately trained medical professionals and service providers on gender-based violence further stifles women's access to quality healthcare, particularly for survivors of Sexual and Gender-Based Violence (SGBV). Given the country is moving towards an ageing population, adequate infrastructure and trained carers are necessary to address the burden of unpaid care work which disproportionately affects women.

The discourse on women's rights and gender equality in Sri Lanka is often framed through nationalist ideologies which see such a discourse as being part of a Western or NGO-inspired conspiracy or through cultural degradation. However, recent regressive global discourses around gender and women's rights have rapidly permeated the country resulting in a narrowed definition of gender that limits its meaning to sexual and gender minorities, disregarding the broader definitions of gender which emerged as part of the development discourse. They also attempt to downplay evidence of a broader understanding of gender and sexuality that have existed in Sri Lanka's culture, religions and history. Victorian-era colonial laws that criminalize gender and sexual identities are still vehemently defended. Furthermore, politics informed by ethno-religious nationalisms have produced the othering of women from certain ethnicities to establish superiority through language, ethnicity and religion. Women continue to experience infringement of their freedom to religious and cultural beliefs and practices.

The disenfranchisement of plantation communities, including the Malaiyaha community, have trapped women and girls for decades in jobs, homes and infrastructure shaped by harsh colonial legacies.

The promise of prosperity after liberalization in the late 1970s did not materialize for Sri Lankan women, who are significantly represented among those living in poverty. Their dispossession from rural land and economies by allowing foreign capital to enter the rural sector resulted in migration of labour to urban centers and abroad under harrowing working conditions and exploitation, while the country's food system has been made more vulnerable. It also led to the change in the structure of Sri Lanka's economy, which now relies on three main foreign exchange earning sectors – garments, tea plantations and remittances of migrant labour – which are predicated on cheap women's labour. Despite their significant contribution to the national economy, women continue to receive a disproportionately small share of the wealth and income they help to generate. Gendered wage inequalities are present in every sector where women are economically engaged.

High levels of indebtedness victimize women through exploitative microfinance loans, resulting in loss of land, assets and increased violence. Women continue to face obstacles to access the formal banking systems to raise the necessary capital for their livelihoods and small businesses at non-exploitative interest rates. Harmful development projects have made some rural areas uninhabitable, while the lack of basic infrastructure such as safe transportation services for women, child-care facilities and market access, further exacerbate the situation for rural women.

Women have faced the brunt of the prolonged armed conflict in the country, facing long-term displacements, sacrificing their family members for combat, interrogation and arrests under the draconian Prevention of Terrorism Act, enforced disappearances, sexual and physical violence, disabilities and loss of lives. The post-war period has seen many struggles by women's collectives to address war-time atrocities, for truth and justice, to return their lands, to rebuild their homes and for decent livelihoods. Women activists in those struggles and women who engaged in combat during the war are under continuous surveillance.

The 2022 economic crisis disproportionately impacted women as they were forced to shoulder the double burden of managing the home amidst skyrocketing inflation and finding paid employment in a collapsed economy. Women's unpaid carework was made visible momentarily during the economic crisis as protestors brought pots, pans and gas cylinders to curb-side protests. While there is pressure to increase female labour force participation in Sri Lanka, there is no equal effort to accurately calculate women's paid and unpaid contributions to the economy, maintain sex-disaggregated data and develop infrastructure to support carework.

The International Monetary Fund (IMF)-led recovery programme ensured that government spending on public services was curtailed and the debt restructuring process included cuts to returns on hard-earned employee provident funds, often the only savings women in the formal sector have post-retirement. The removal of subsidies on water, fuel, and electricity, alongside the introduction of market-based pricing, has left many households unable to pay their bills, resulting in the disconnection of services and increasing the burden on women at home.

Sri Lanka has faced two major disasters in recent decades—the Indian Ocean tsunami and Cyclone Ditwah—in addition to recurring climate related annual floods and droughts. However, the gender-neutral approach to climate and disaster management has caused distress and losses for women, particularly for disabled and elderly women. Currently, sex-disaggregated data for climate related disasters are not available, while evacuation procedures and access to safe temporary shelters have been hugely inadequate for disabled and elderly women. Furthermore, women are excluded from disaster and climate crisis management committees or bodies. While women in some districts are organized for climate action and disaster responses, there is no formal system established for their participation. As Sri Lanka braces for the impact of El Nino, it is yet to be seen whether gender-responsive approaches are adopted, including training and deploying women as first responders, ensuring language parity in government communications regarding disasters, addressing violence during disasters and ensuring just compensation for losses.

As the country moves ahead amidst a volatile global and local context for women's rights, key issues emerged as top priorities for NCW to address:

- recognizing women's contribution to the economy, and ensuring economic safeguards and economic justice for women;
- ensuring safety for girls and women and freedom from all forms of violence;
- access to gender-responsive justice mechanisms for violations;
- protecting the rights of marginalized women, including religious and ethnic minorities, women with disabilities, and women with diverse sexual and gender identities;
- ensuring women's representation and equal participation at all decision-making levels;
- ensuring access to free, quality and informed healthcare for women and including gender-responsive policies and mechanisms.

4. NCW's Strategic Plan (2027 – 2031)

Our Vision
සියලුම කාන්තාවන් සමානාත්මතාවය, ගෞරවය සහ යුක්තිය උපරිමයෙන් භුක්ති විඳින ශ්‍රී ලංකාවක්.
இலங்கையின் சகல பெண்களும் சமத்துவம், கௌரவம் மற்றும் நீதிக்கான உரிமையை அடைதல்.
All women in Sri Lanka enjoy their right to equality, dignity and justice.
Our Mission
ස්වාධීන අධීක්ෂණය, උපදේශනය, සියලු දෙනාගේ සහභාගීත්වය සහ වගවීම ශක්තිමත් කිරීම තුළින් කාන්තා අයිතිවාසිකම් සහ ස්ත්‍රී පුරුෂ සමානාත්මතාවය ආරක්ෂා කිරීම සහ ප්‍රවර්ධනය කිරීම.
பெண்களின் உரிமை மற்றும் பால்நிலை சமத்துவம் முதலானவற்றை சுயாதீன மேற்பார்வை, சகலரின் பங்குபற்றல் மற்றும் பொறுப்புக்கூறல் மூலம் பாதுகாத்தலும் மேம்படுத்தலும்.
To protect and promote women's rights and gender equality through independent oversight, advocacy, and strengthening inclusive participation and accountability.

NCW's five-year Strategic Plan (2027-2031) has been developed based on its mandate, strategic analysis of the external context and its internal strengths and weaknesses.

Three thematic areas have been identified by prioritizing the work NCW will take forward within this five-year period: a) Access to Justice, b) Safety, Peace and Security and c) Access to Resources and Opportunities. NCW has also identified six strategic interventions which will cut across the three thematic areas: Policy and Law Reform; Inquiry, Litigation and Mediation; Referrals and Collaboration; Monitoring; Research and Fact Finding; and Advocacy.

The National Fund for Women, which will be set up by and managed by NCW, will contribute towards both the delivery of its thematic areas and institutional strategies. The thematic areas will be supported and anchored by strategies for Institutional Development (See *Image 1* below).

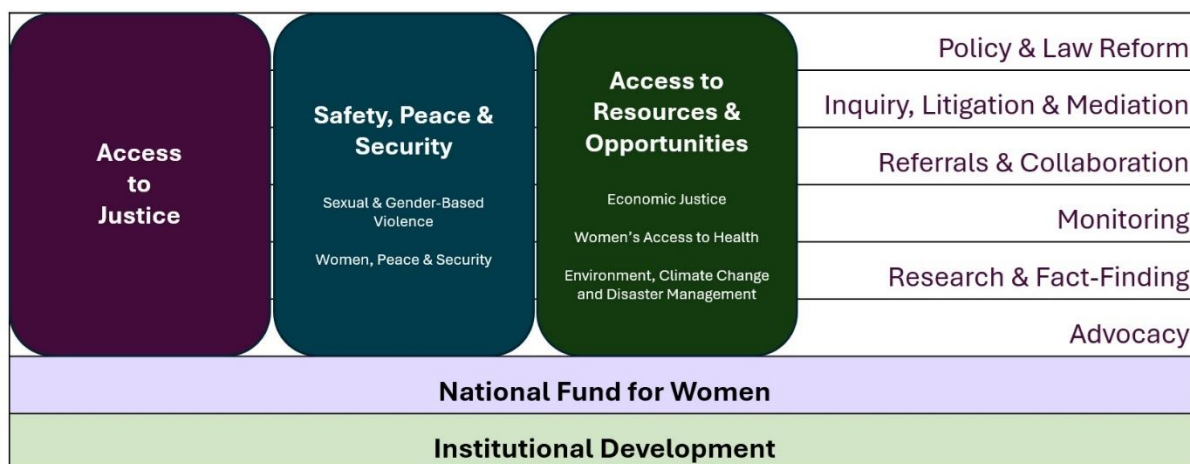


Image 1

➤ Theme 1: Access to Justice

Objective: *To promote gender responsive laws and policies relating to access to justice, equal participation and representation.*

The ‘Access to Justice’ thematic area forms the heart of NCW’s work and links to the other two thematic areas. The theme addresses two distinct areas identified through the strategic planning process: challenges faced by women when accessing existing laws and mechanisms, and addressing obstacles to women’s equal participation, representation and leadership in public institutions, governance and politics.

Under this thematic area, the NCW will establish its own investigation, inquiry, and mediation processes, as well as a regional presence, both of which will significantly strengthen gender-responsive mechanisms available to women in Sri Lanka.

The thematic area will include a gendered analysis of existing laws and policies for compliance with CEDAW and advocate for gender-responsive laws and policies. NCW will specifically intervene in ongoing law reform processes and provide gendered analysis and recommendations to ensure they are gender-responsive and promote women’s rights.

A key aspect of work in this thematic area is to monitor and provide oversight for the implementation of the National Policy on Gender Equality and Women’s Empowerment 2023-2033 by liaising with relevant ministries, government bodies and authorities.

NCW will promote the availability of sex-disaggregated data to understand the status of women’s representation and participation in key law enforcement, governance and public institutions. Furthermore, it will advocate new laws and policies to increase women’s meaningful participation and representation in decision-making bodies at all levels of public institutions, governance structures and political parties.

➤ Theme 2: Safety, Peace and Security

Objective: Gender-responsive access to justice is ensured in relation to safety, peace and security.

The ‘Safety, Peace and Security’ thematic area includes two distinct sub-themes: a) sexual and gender-based violence and b) women, peace and security.

The consultations revealed that women struggle to access laws that are in existence to prevent SGBV and to obtain justice for survivors who have experienced SGBV. It was also noted that no comprehensive study on rape has been conducted in the country in recent times, resulting in a significant knowledge gap. While the ratification of ILO Convention 190 is welcomed, a very specific law addressing sexual and gender-based violence at workplaces and its implementation is crucial to reducing SGBV at the workplace.

Conflict-related violations of women’s rights, particularly in relation to SGBV, disability, and truth-seeking, remain insufficiently addressed, despite more than 15 years having passed since the end of the war. Conflict-affected women continue to face surveillance, barriers to accessing justice, and the militarisation of their lands and livelihoods. Addressing conflict-related violations of women’s rights, ensuring access to justice for war-affected women, and strengthening safeguards against the continuing impacts of ethnic, religious, and cultural tensions on women remain key priorities under this theme.

❖ ***Sub-Theme 2.1: Sexual and Gender-Based Violence***

A key contribution of NCW under this sub-thematic area will be to give input, monitor and provide oversight for the implementation of the Multisectoral National Action Plan to Address Sexual and Gender-Based Violence 2024-2028, by liaising with relevant government entities and authorities.

NCW will intervene in addressing the obstacles to accessing laws relating to SGBV and monitor the progress of existing laws and their impact. Furthermore, NCW will advocate to address sexual harassment, including in public transport and in the workplace, with a specific focus on the implementation of ILO Convention 190 which was ratified by the Sri Lankan government in April 2026. The Commission will also engage with boys and men to prevent SGBV, including sexual harassment.

During the five-year period NCW will undertake a flagship islandwide study on rape. NCW will address technology facilitated SGBV, by developing survivor-centered mechanisms for investigations and redress.

NCW will advocate for the decriminalization of laws that target women based on gender and sexual identities. It will advocate for educational reforms that are underway to address harmful gender stereotypes.

❖ *Sub-Theme 2.2: Women, Peace and Security*

Under the sub-theme of ‘Women, Peace and Security’, NCW will monitor and provide input and oversight on the National Action Plan for Women, Peace and Security 2023-2027, by liaising with the relevant ministries, government bodies and authorities.

The NCW will advocate for addressing the challenges faced by women with conflict-related disabilities and women survivors of conflict-related sexual and other forms of violence, including access to necessary economic, social, and legal support.

NCW will advocate for the increased representation of women in the police and security forces. Addressing the impact on women living under militarization, continuous surveillance and protection for women activists will also form part of NCW’s work under this sub-thematic area.

NCW will document the gendered impacts of violations in relation to freedom of religion or beliefs, monitor emerging trends, and advocate for accountability, legal and policy reforms.

➤ Theme 3: Access to Resources and Opportunities

Objective: to promote gender responsive laws, policies and practices in the workplace, access to gender responsive health services that cover all phases of a woman’s life, and gender-responsive actions to climate change and disasters.

The third thematic area forms the major focus of the five-year strategic plan and includes important interventions for economic justice, free and quality access to women’s health and greater participation of women in decision-making in relation to addressing climate change and disaster management. It will aim to strengthen gender-responsive budgeting and ensure the systematic collection and use of sex-disaggregated data to inform policy and planning.

❖ *Sub-Theme 3.1: Economic Justice*

Under the sub-theme of ‘Economic Justice’ NCW will provide a gendered perspective on laws relating to women’s labour, including providing recommendations to the ongoing labour reforms process.

NCW will advocate for the recognition of women’s contribution to the national economy. It will also advocate for implementing existing labour laws that protect the rights of women workers specifically in the Export Processing Zones. It will also review and make recommendations for gender-responsive repatriation processes for migrant workers.

NCW will advocate for free training, accreditation and licensing for small livelihoods and businesses led by women. Ensuring non-discriminatory and non-exploitative access to credit through public banks for women will be promoted.

NCW will advocate for expanding social protection for women workers in the informal sector. It will also contribute to the ongoing policy discussions on unpaid care work.

❖ ***Sub-Theme 3.2: Women's Access to Health***

The 'Women's Access to Health' sub-theme will include interventions to promote free and quality healthcare for women throughout their lifespan by ensuring adequate allocations are included in the national budgets for women's health.

NCW will promote addressing period poverty and menstrual hygiene in schools for girls. It will also advocate for age-appropriate sex education in schools and access to sexual and reproductive health services for women.

NCW will propose law reforms to safeguard the labour rights of women in pregnancy, post-partum and early-motherhood. It will also advocate for comprehensive geriatric medical services for elderly women.

NCW will address harmful practices such as female genital mutilation and illegal abortions that may threaten the life of the woman. It will also advocate for the health and wellbeing of transgender community and their access to gender-affirming healthcare.

❖ ***Sub-Theme 3.3: Environment, Climate Change and Disasters***

The sub-theme on 'Environment, Climate Change and Disasters' will address the inadequate representation of women in decision-making bodies in relation to climate and disaster management, and the education of officials involved on gender-sensitive approaches for the same.

NCW will advocate for sex disaggregated data in relation to climate change and disaster management. It will also promote greater awareness about reducing violence against women during disaster situations.

NCW will advocate for reducing economic impacts and health impacts of climate-change on women.

NCW will promote the recognition of women championing the cause of environmental protection and reducing the impacts of climate change and positive portrayal of women's contributions in the media.

➤ National Fund for Women

Objective: *To manage and disburse the funds voted by Parliament, received from local or foreign sources and sales of assets for expenses of the commission and ex-gratia payments for any individual or organisation for the exceptional and outstanding contributions to women's rights.*

NCW will set up the National Fund for Women and develop the policies and procedures for the management of the Fund, including guidelines for raising funds, and the disbursement of funds.

NCW will utilize the Fund for specific purposes as outlined in the Women Empowerment Act.

NCW will establish internal and independent control mechanisms and establish a Fund Management Committee as an oversight mechanism for the Fund.

➤ Institutional Development

The NCW faces a distinct challenge in establishing a permanent, independent state institution with a unique mandate, whilst ensuring it can become rapidly operational. At the outset it is noted that the NCW does not have the option of becoming fully operational and then delivering on its mandate for a number of reasons, including the urgency of issues to be addressed, the long delays already experienced by victim-survivors seeking redress from other state institutions, the need to gain confidence of the public and acceptance of state institutions, accountability and annual audits, among others.

As such, institutional development will take place in a phased manner that may extend well beyond the five-year Strategic Plan, as borne out by the experience of other independent state institutions. Nonetheless, a key focus of the first year of NCW will be on establishing the core of the institution to ensure autonomy, responsiveness, effectiveness, engagement and trust-building through programmes and activities that will be implemented over the years of the Strategic Plan.

Infrastructure: Operationalizing the NCW requires addressing critical infrastructure needs. Having been assigned a property at No. 110/9, Wijerama Mawatha, Colombo 7, by the Ministry of Public Administration, Provincial Councils and Local Government, the Commission will renovate and refurbish the building prior to establishing its office premises. Subsequently, the NCW will procure essential office furniture, ICT equipment, and other operational assets for staff positions approved by the Department of Management Services.

Human Resources: Recognizing the urgency to become operational and given the lengthy processes in immediately securing skilled staff, NCW will adopt a strategic human resource model that combines permanent staff with volunteer positions and consultant support. This will also allow NCW to access specific skill sets and expertise that may not be available through the permanent staff positions.

A programme of structured and ongoing capacity development will be implemented to ensure that Commissioners and staff possess the knowledge and competencies required to effectively discharge their responsibilities. This will include structured induction programmes, thematic and conceptual familiarization sessions on key national and international frameworks, as well as regular policy dialogues and knowledge-sharing sessions with national and international experts to strengthen strategic leadership and institutional effectiveness.

As part of its institutional governance framework, the NCW will develop several internal guidelines, policies and operational instruments to ensure standardized and systematic approaches are in place to address grievances, conduct relevant programmes and ensure transparency and accountability.

Financial Management: While NCW will rely primarily on the funds it obtains for its operations and programmes, it will work towards setting up the National Fund for Women as mandated by the Women Empowerment Act, to ensure greater financial independence.

To strengthen its financial governance framework, NCW will establish comprehensive financial procedures and systems aligned with government financial regulations and good governance practices.

NCW will purchase and implement a computerized Financial Management Information System. This system will integrate key organisational functions, including procurement, human resource management, payroll, asset management, and budgeting. This digital solution will enhance internal controls, transparency, accountability, and evidence-based decision-making across NCW.

Communication, Outreach and Public Engagement: Building public awareness and establishing the Commission as an independent commission promoting and protecting women's rights will be a strategic priority during the first five years. During this time, the Commission will lay the foundation for its digital presence through a trilingual and accessible website as well as via official social media platforms to deliver regular, timely, and engaging content to enhance public awareness, increase stakeholder engagement, and promote transparency and accountability.

Recognizing that effective engagement requires both national visibility and local presence, NCW will initiate an outreach programme across all nine provinces. This will include regular consultations and collaborative engagement with key state institutions—including with Ministries, Government Departments, the Judiciary, Police, Provincial Councils, District and Divisional Secretariats—as well as other public institutions responsible for advancing gender equality and protecting women's rights, particularly other independent commissions.

The Commission will also undertake district-level consultations in all nine provinces and strengthen partnerships with women-led and women's rights organisations, civil society organisations, community-based organisations, grassroots networks, and community leaders. These initiatives will ensure that the voices and lived experiences of women from diverse communities inform the Commission's work while improving access to its services at the local level.

5. Monitoring, Evaluation & Learning

The Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning (MEL) Framework⁵ articulates how NCW plans to monitor its results; how periodic data collection and analyses will guide and accompany implementation; and how the information generated from the MEL framework will be reflected upon and used to improve the Commission's performance. The overall objective of the MEL framework is to monitor not only the performance but also the outcomes and wider social impact in relation to women's rights and gender equality that NCW hopes to contribute towards.

The process of developing an MEL framework for NCW began with an intentional articulation of thematic objectives and outcomes. Understanding and articulating the intended change sets a base for the MEL framework. Indicators were developed at multiple levels: output indicators tracking the commission's own performance and outcome indicators tracking uptake and influence. These indicators were also assessed against the feasibility of data collection, to identify data collection methods and frequency, of both data collection and data analyses.

The Commission also noted the need to develop its own guidelines on gender-responsive MEL practices, to safeguard confidentiality and to ensure that the Commission sets standards for a gender-responsive, participatory, rights-based approach in its MEL framework.

⁵ See Annexure 1 for MEL Framework

Annexure 1: Monitoring, Evaluation & Learning Framework

No.	Objectives & Outcomes	Performance Indicators
1	Access to Justice <i>To promote gender-responsive laws and policies relating to access to justice, equal participation and representation.</i>	
	- Existing laws, policies and other mechanisms that protect and promote gender equality are fully implemented. - Laws and policies that violate and discriminate on the basis of gender are reformed. - Gender-responsive national-level independent mechanisms to promote access to justice are established.	- Effectiveness and timeliness of complaint resolution. - Effectiveness and timeliness of mediation. - Status of reforms to key laws that violate / discriminate against women's rights. # of persons accessing NCW's regional justice support services. # of women in various committees in targeted local authorities.
2	Safety, Peace & Security <i>To ensure gender-responsive access to justice, in relation to safety, peace and security.</i>	
2.1	Sexual and Gender-Based Violence <i>Ensure that domestic laws, policies and programmes are compliant with SGBV provisions in CEDAW.</i>	
	- Women's voices are represented in the reform process of domestic laws, policies and programmes relating to SGBV. - Domestic laws and policies are reformed to be compliant with SGBV provisions in CEDAW.	# and nature of laws, policies and other legal instruments passed by 2031 in compliance with SGBV provisions in CEDAW. - NCW has a presence and voice in the reform process relating to SGBV.
2.2	Women, Peace and Security <i>Ensure that domestic laws, policies and programmes are compliant with CEDAW provisions on Women affected by Armed Conflict and UNSCR1325.</i>	
	- Conflict affected women's voices are represented in ongoing ethnic and religious reconciliation process. - Domestic laws, policies and programmes are compliant with CEDAW provisions on Women in Conflict and UNSCR1325.	# and nature of laws, policies and other legal instruments passed by 2031 compliant with CEDAW provisions on Women in Conflict and UNSCR1325. # of NCW recommendations incorporating the voices of conflict affected women adopted in ongoing ethnic and religious reconciliation processes.
3	Access to Resources and Opportunities <i>To promote gender responsive laws, policies and practices in the workplace, access to gender responsive health services that cover all phases of a woman's life, and gender responsive responses to climate change and disasters.</i>	
3.1	Economic Justice:	

	<i>To create an inclusive, safe, and equitable labour market that advances women's economic rights, improves working conditions, recognizes unpaid care work, and ensures equal access to employment, social protection, and economic opportunities.</i>	
	• Women have equal access to economic opportunities provided by state and non-state actors. • Laws and policies promote and protect the rights of women at the workplace. • Gender-sensitive financial inclusion policies developed and implemented. • increased access of women to formal financial services and credit schemes.	• # and nature of recommendations made by NCW adopted in the labour law reforms. • # of targeted businesses compliant with Shop and Office Ordinance (especially in relation to maternity benefits). • # of guidelines for worker rights issued by NCW and adopted by FTZ and plantation companies. • # of recommendations for financial inclusion issued by NCW adopted by the financial regulators. • Increased number of women entrepreneurs (SMEs) receiving certified training, licences, and quality accreditation support.
3.2	Women's Access to Health <i>To establish an inclusive, gender-responsive national framework that guarantees complete bodily autonomy, universal access to sexual and reproductive health services, and socioeconomic protections for women and marginalized groups throughout their lifespan.</i>	
	• Increased access to gender-responsive health services throughout the life course of women.	• Comprehensive Sexuality Education added into school and university curricula. • Increase in government budget line for the specific areas of women's health. • # of NCW recommendations implemented in medical and nursing curricula. • # of relevant reforms, laws, policies and circulars informed by NCW.
3.3	Environment, Climate Change and Disaster Management <i>Positioning and strengthening women's leadership, participation and agency in environmental governance, climate change adaptation and mitigation, and disaster management while addressing gendered impacts.</i>	
	• Increased leadership and participation of women in environmental protection and climate justice initiatives • State and non-state actors adopt gender sensitive responses to climate change and disasters	• Availability of national and district-level sex-disaggregated data on the gendered impacts of climate change and disasters. • # and types of spaces (including committees) where women are represented in environmental, climate change and disaster management decision-making and policy formulation processes. • Gender-responsive measures incorporated into environment, climate change and disaster preparedness, recovery and climate adaptation frameworks.